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EMPOWERING JOURNEYS: A Definitive Collection of Books for Healing from Trauma

Oliver Inderwildi 7 min read · Dec 20, 2023

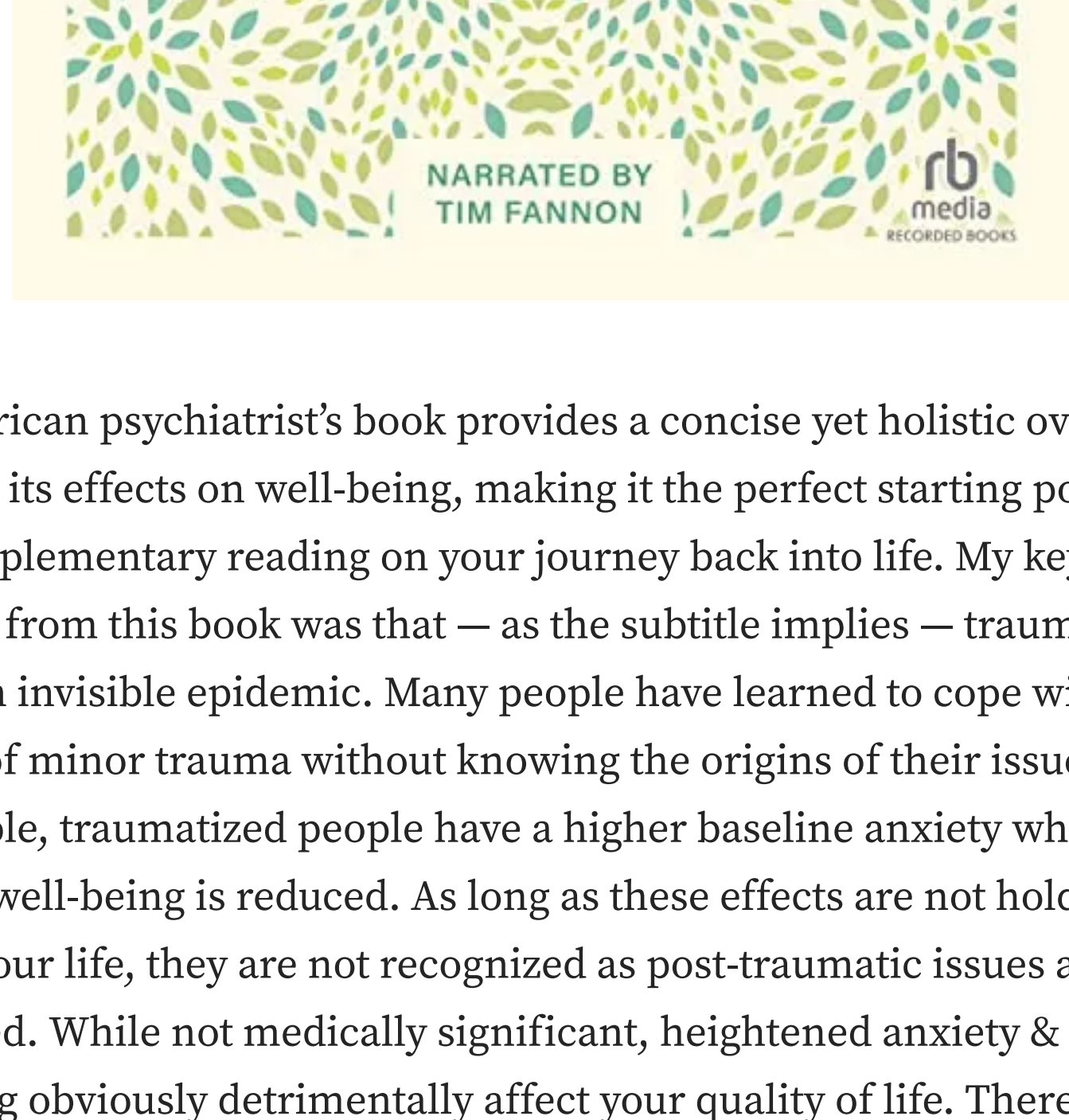
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Overcoming post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD), especially severe cases, can be the challenge of a lifetime. No matter whether accidents, disease, war experience, or abuse have induced the debilitating disease, its effects — both physiologically and psychologically — are not only long-lasting but also challenging to address. In the case of PTSD, standard treatments with commonly effective antidepressants such as SSRIs are often in vain, while trauma therapy is a lengthy process. Short-term relief is hence not easily achieved, but novel routes such as treatment with psychedelics or stellate ganglion blocks can provide some relief. So, if you are suffering from PTSD, you're in for a marathon, an ultra-marathon really.

Yet, within adversity lies opportunity: The goal is to come out the other end more resilient, more empathic, and more balanced. Alas, there are no guarantees to success.

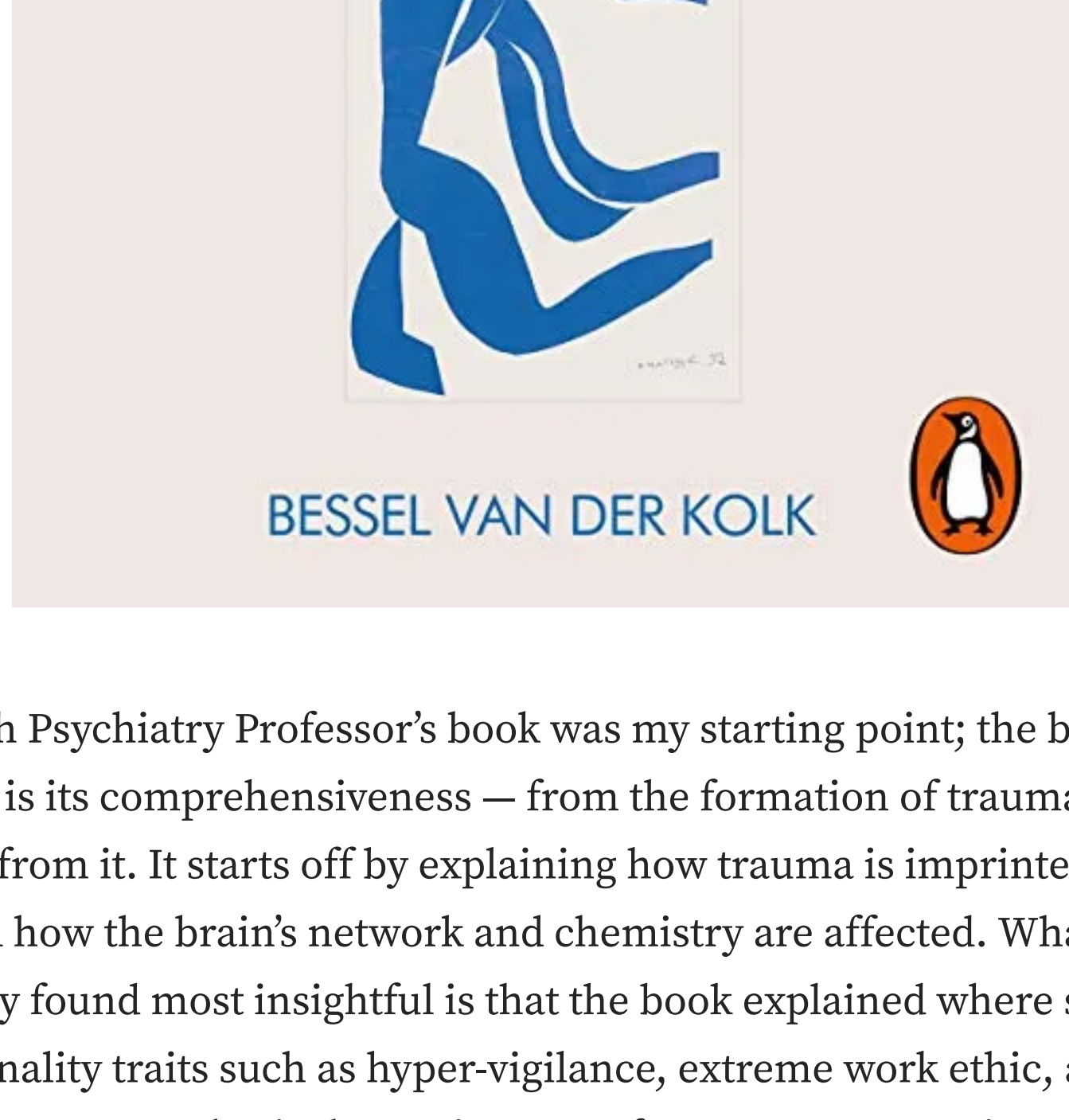
Depending on the severity of the trauma, your journey might require assistance from medical professionals supporting it with medication and therapy. To accompany the journey towards a restored self, reading about the ailment and its symptoms is, in my opinion, essential. The following books and videos gave me not only a better understanding of the disease but also pointed out things that I could incorporate into my daily routine to ease the effects, essentially guiding me through my exciting but challenging journey. From the bottom of my heart, I hope that this write-up will help you to get started on your journey towards health, well-being, and a renewed zest for life.

Paul Conti's "Trauma — The Invisible Epidemic"



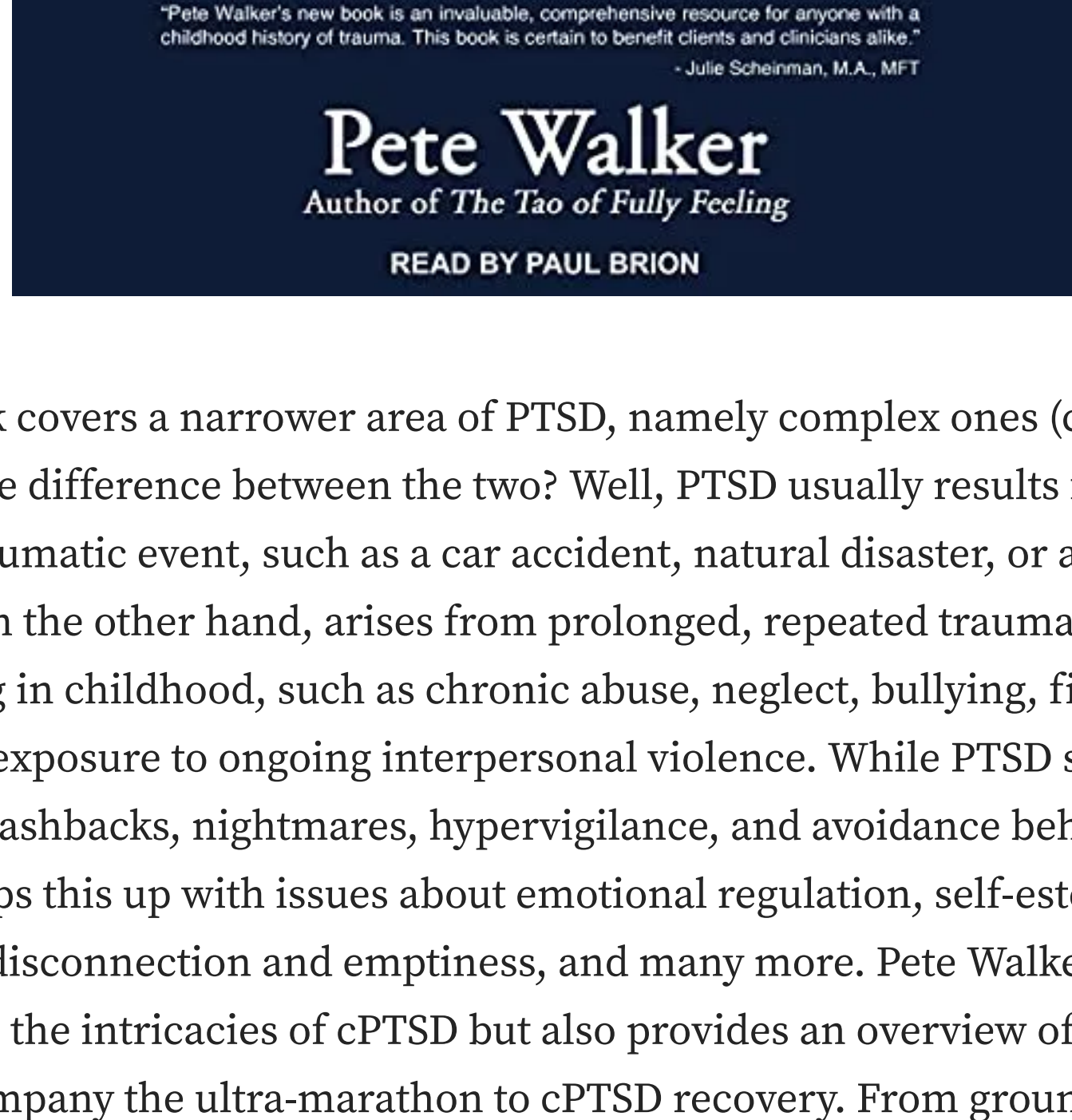
The American psychiatrist's book provides a concise yet holistic overview of trauma & its effects on well-being, making it the perfect starting point for your complementary reading on your journey back into life. My key takeaway from this book was that — as the subtitle implies — trauma is indeed an invisible epidemic. Many people have learned to cope with the impacts of minor trauma without knowing the origins of their issues. To give an example, traumatized people have a higher baseline anxiety while their baseline well-being is reduced. As long as these effects are not holding you back in your life, they are not recognized as post-traumatic issues and hence not treated. While not medically significant, heightened anxiety & lowered well-being obviously detrimentally affect your quality of life. Therefore, most people could benefit from working through their mini-traumas while improving their lives by minimizing personal problems. Moreover, Conti's book dives deep into shame and elaborates on why traumatized people feel ashamed for what happened to them; a good starting point is that trauma was inflicted on you and consequently is not your responsibility. The first step of your journey is hence to accept that trauma is nothing you should feel ashamed of; in the end, it was inflicted on you!

Bessel van der Kolk's "The Body Keeps the Score"



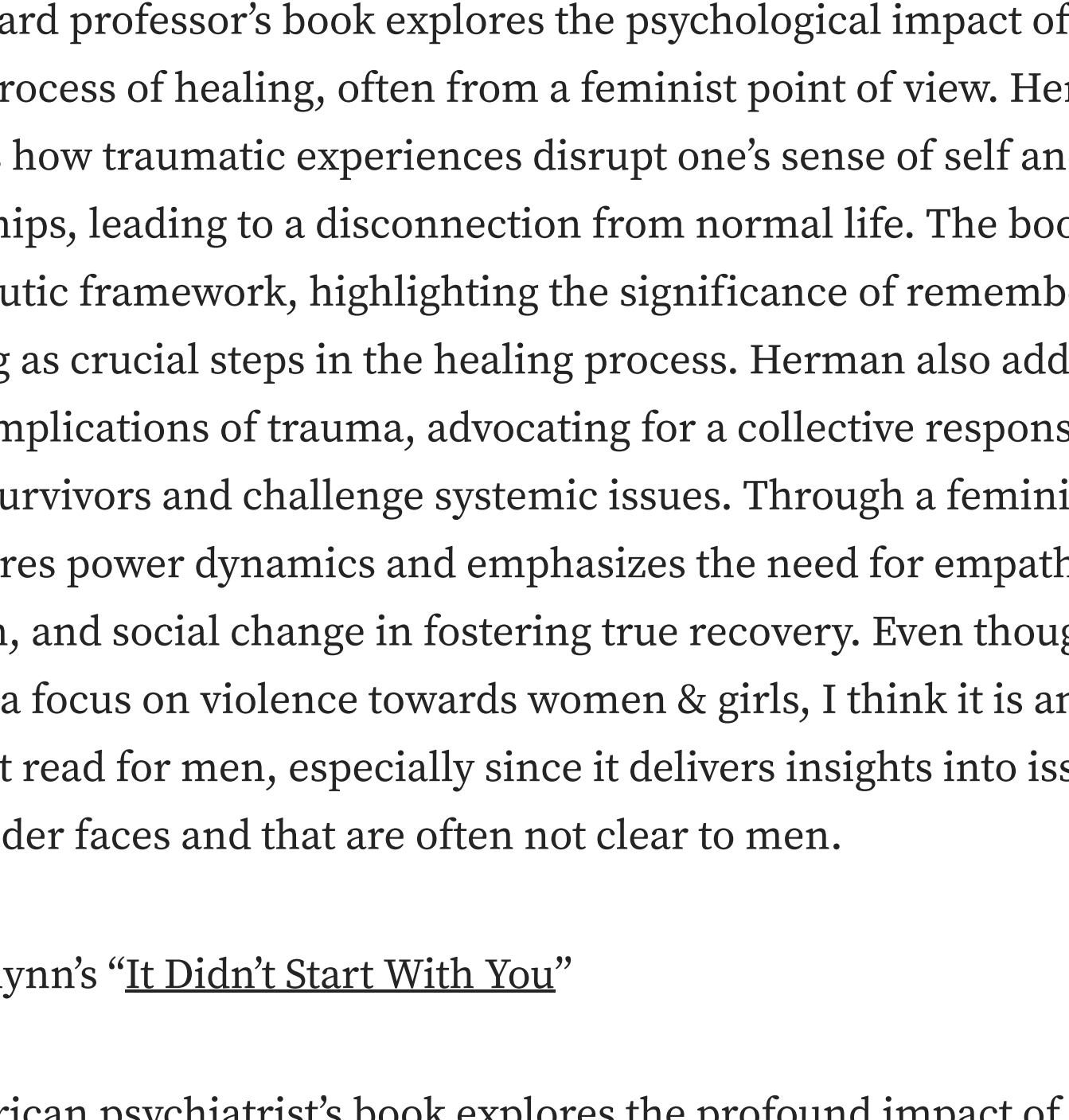
The Dutch Psychiatry Professor's book was my starting point; the beauty of this book is its comprehensiveness — from the formation of trauma to recovery from it. It starts off by explaining how trauma is imprinted on the brain and how the brain's network and chemistry are affected. What I personally found most insightful is that the book explained where some of my personality traits such as hyper-vigilance, extreme work ethic, and the need for strenuous physical exercise come from. Moreover, minor physical ailments such as irritable bowel syndrome (IBS) and a sleep disorder, which have bothered me most of my life, are likely due to trauma imprinted at a very early age. Coping with the emotional and physical consequences of trauma for many years will leave you drained, and you will need to recover your energy. This is where van der Kolk's book will help you on your journey, as it presents a compelling exploration of innovative therapeutic approaches that address the intricate interplay between trauma, memory, and recovery. These range from seeing a therapist, especially for internal family systems (IFS) therapy, to Eye Movement Desensitization and Reprocessing (EMDR), neuro- and bio-feedback, yoga, theater, and interventions with psychedelics. Once you have read and internalized van der Kolk's book, you are set for the journey; just pick the levers out that suit you most and get going!

Pete Walker's "Complex PTSD: From Surviving to Thriving"



This book covers a narrower area of PTSD, namely complex ones (cPTSD). What's the difference between the two? Well, PTSD usually results from a single traumatic event, such as a car accident, natural disaster, or assault. cPTSD, on the other hand, arises from prolonged, repeated trauma, often occurring in childhood, such as chronic abuse, neglect, bullying, financial woes, or exposure to ongoing interpersonal violence. While PTSD symptoms include flashbacks, nightmares, hypervigilance, and avoidance behaviors, cPTSD tops this up with issues about emotional regulation, self-esteem, a sense of disconnection and emptiness, and many more. Pete Walker not only describes the intricacies of cPTSD but also provides an overview of tools that can accompany the ultra-marathon to cPTSD recovery. From grounding techniques, self-compassion, mindfulness, and establishing clear boundaries to inner child work and cognitive-behavioral techniques. So, if you are suffering from cPTSD, this book is an excellent resource.

Judith Lewis Herman's "Trauma & Recovery"



The Harvard professor's book explores the psychological impact of trauma and the process of healing, often from a feminist point of view. Herman examines how traumatic experiences disrupt one's sense of self and relationships, leading to a disconnection from normal life. The book outlines a therapeutic framework, highlighting the significance of remembering and mourning as crucial steps in the healing process. Herman also addresses the societal implications of trauma, advocating for a collective responsibility to support survivors and challenge systemic issues. Through a feminist lens, she explores power dynamics and emphasizes the need for empathy, validation, and social change in fostering true recovery. Even though the book has a focus on violence towards women & girls, I think it is an important read for men, especially since it delivers insights into issues the other gender faces and that are often not clear to men.

Mark Wolynn's "It Didn't Start With You"

The American psychiatrist's book explores the profound impact of inherited family trauma on our relationships, health, and overall life. Wolynn introduces the concept of epigenetics, suggesting that the experiences and traumas of our ancestors can be imprinted on our genes and passed down through generations. The book delves into real-life case studies and examples, illustrating how individuals may carry the emotional and psychological burdens of their family's past without even being consciously aware of it. Wolynn argues that these inherited traumas can manifest in various ways, influencing our behavior, choices, and even our physical health. As the books mentioned above, Wolynn argues that becoming aware of the trauma enables us to break the cycle and release these deep-seated issues. The book also offers a roadmap to break free from the invisible chains that hold traumatized people back.

The books recommended above should really help you with working through trauma and complement medical as well as therapeutic interventions. Not only the increased comprehension of the disease that I acquire from these books helped me a lot, but also the little interventions recommended supported me in managing the symptoms.

In essence, the path to overcoming post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) unfolds as a profound journey, demanding a blend of medical, therapeutic, and self-help interventions. Despite the inherent challenges, it is crucial to underscore the potential for resilience to sprout from adversity. Within the struggle lies a transformative opportunity, and the suggested resources stand as guiding beacons, steering individuals toward health, well-being, and a revitalized enthusiasm for life. In the quest for healing, recognizing and confronting the invisible chains of trauma holds the power to foster empowerment, resilience, and, in the end, a renewed sense of self.

Wishing you the best of luck on your journey!

To reach out to Oliver, please connect with him on [LinkedIn](#) or follow him on [Twitter](#). You can watch lectures, talks, interviews and podcasts with Oliver on [YouTube](#).

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